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MUS 101: Fundamentals of Music Theory - Notation, Scales and Rhythm

Read, write and hear the basics before analysis

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
Music | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

This pack covers staff notation, clefs, note values and metre, major and minor scales, intervals, triads, and the basics of African rhythmic organisation including polyrhythm and the standard pattern. It ends with an ear-training routine you can run without a piano.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Read and write notes on treble and bass staves.
- Construct major and minor scales and identify intervals.
- Build and identify triads.
- Describe polyrhythm and the standard pattern in African music.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Notation fundamentals

Notation is a tool for thought, not a substitute for hearing.

- Staff, clefs, ledger lines and the grand staff.
- Note values: whole, half, quarter, eighth, sixteenth and their rests.
- Dots and ties change duration, not pitch.
- Time signatures: simple, compound and irregular metre.
- Key signatures and the circle of fifths.
- Accidentals apply within the bar unless cancelled.

Scales, intervals and chords

Patterns make transposition manageable.

- Major scale pattern: tone-tone-semitone-tone-tone-tone-semitone.
- Natural, harmonic and melodic minor.
- Interval quality: major, minor, perfect, augmented, diminished.
- Triads: major, minor, diminished and augmented.
- Roman numeral analysis for progressions.
- Modes and pentatonic scales beyond the European common practice.

> **Sing what you write**
> If you cannot sing a scale or interval, you do not yet know it. Singing connects notation to hearing.

African rhythmic organisation

African music theory is not an appendix to European theory.

- The standard pattern (the 'short' bell pattern) as a timeline reference.
- Polyrhythm: simultaneous contrasting rhythmic layers.
- Cross-rhythm and the relationship of 3 against 2 or 12/8 feels.
- Call and response as a structural principle.
- Timeline instruments anchor ensemble coordination.
- Transcription is an interpretation; note your choices.

Pitch is measured, not guessed

Western music theory names twelve pitch classes and organises them into scales. A major scale follows the interval pattern tone-tone-semitone-tone-tone-tone-semitone; a natural minor scale follows tone-semitone-tone-tone-semitone-tone-tone. Everything else - key signatures, chords, transposition - follows from these patterns.

Intervals are the distance between two notes, named by size and quality: a major third, a perfect fifth, a minor seventh. Counting semitones is the reliable method: a perfect fifth is seven semitones, a major third four, a minor third three. Learn the semitone count for each interval and you can construct any chord.

Nigerian music theory is not a subset of Western theory. Igbo and Yoruba tonal systems organise melody around speech tone, and the pentatonic scales common in many Nigerian traditions do not map neatly onto diatonic harmony. A student who transcribes a traditional melody into a major key has usually altered it. The comparison between systems is itself examinable.

Rhythm, metre, and the thing notation hides

Rhythm is the organisation of durations; metre is the repeating pattern of strong and weak beats. A time signature states the metre - 4/4 is four crotchet beats per bar - but the felt pulse is what performers actually organise around. A listener can clap to 4/4 without reading a score.

Syncopation places emphasis off the beat, and polyrhythm places two or more rhythmic patterns in simultaneous conflict. Both are central to much African music, where a single cycle may be organised by several interlocking parts and the "beat" emerges from the relationship rather than being stated by one instrument. This is why transcribing such music into a single Western metre often loses the structure.

Master rhythms are named and learned as cycles: a bell pattern establishes the timeline, and other parts interlock with it. Understanding this makes clear that rhythm in such traditions is compositional architecture, not accompaniment.

> **Clap before you notate**
> If you cannot clap the pattern steadily and say where the cycle restarts, you do not yet understand it well enough to write it down.

Harmony and form

A triad is three notes stacked in thirds. Major, minor, diminished and augmented triads differ by their interval content. In a key, chords are numbered by scale degree: I, ii, iii, IV, V, vi, vii. The common progressions students must recognise by ear are I-IV-V-I, I-vi-IV-V and the twelve-bar blues.

Cadences close phrases: perfect (V-I), imperfect (ending on I with the melody on the third), plagal (IV-I), interrupted (V-vi) and half (ending on V). Identifying cadences is a reliable way to find phrase boundaries in an unfamiliar piece.

Form is the large-scale arrangement: binary (AB), ternary (ABA), strophic (verses to the same music), through-composed, and the call-and-response structure central to much African and African-diaspora music. Name the form, then show where the sections divide and what marks the division - a cadence, a texture change, a new rhythmic cycle.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Building a major scale and its chords

Construct the scale of D major and identify its primary triads.

1. Start on D and apply the major pattern: tone, tone, semitone, tone, tone, tone, semitone.
2. Result: D E F# G A B C# D.
3. Check the key signature: two sharps, F# and C#.
4. Build triads on I, IV and V: D major (D-F#-A), G major (G-B-D), A major (A-C#-E).
5. Play the progression I-IV-V-I and listen for the resolution.
6. Transpose the same progression to another key to test the method.

> **What to carry forward**
> Pattern, signature, triads, listening. Never memorise a scale without the pattern.

2. Identifying a cadence by ear

A phrase ends and you must name the cadence.

1. Find the final bass note of the phrase.
2. If it is the tonic and the preceding chord was the dominant, it is perfect.
3. If the melody ends on the third degree over the tonic, it is imperfect.
4. If the phrase ends on the dominant, it is a half cadence.
5. If the expected tonic is replaced by the relative minor, it is interrupted.
6. Confirm by playing the phrase again and singing the bass.

> **What to carry forward**
> Bass note plus preceding chord identifies almost every cadence.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Construct the natural minor scale on A and explain how it differs from A major.

15 marks

1. A natural minor: A B C D E F G A.
2. Interval pattern: tone, semitone, tone, tone, semitone, tone, tone.
3. Compare with A major: three lowered degrees (C, F, G become C natural, F natural, G natural).
4. Note the effect on the primary triads and on cadence strength.
5. Mention the harmonic minor alteration of the seventh.

Q2. Explain polyrhythm and its role in African music, using a named example.

15 marks

1. Define polyrhythm: simultaneous contrasting rhythmic patterns.
2. Describe the timeline pattern and interlocking parts.
3. Give a named ensemble or tradition example.
4. Explain why a single Western metre may misrepresent the structure.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Calling polyrhythm "complex rhythm". Complexity is not the defining feature; simultaneity of patterns is.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Scale. An ordered set of pitches forming the melodic material of a key or mode.

Semitone. The smallest standard interval in Western tuning, adjacent keys on a piano.

Interval. The distance in pitch between two notes, named by size and quality.

Key signature. The sharps or flats at the start of a staff indicating the key.

Triad. A chord of three notes stacked in thirds.

Cadence. A harmonic formula closing a phrase or section.

Metre. The repeating pattern of strong and weak beats.

Syncopation. Emphasis placed on a weak beat or between beats.

Polyrhythm. Two or more contrasting rhythmic patterns sounding simultaneously.

Timeline. A repeated bell or percussion pattern that anchors an ensemble's cycle.

Pentatonic scale. A five-note scale common in many musical traditions.

Form. The large-scale arrangement of sections in a piece.

Transposition. Moving music to a different key while preserving intervals.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Pitch

Scales and intervals.

- Write five major scales from the pattern.
- Count semitones for six intervals.
- Identify key signatures by sight.

Week 2 - Rhythm

Metre and pattern.

- Clap and notate three rhythms.
- Identify syncopation in a recording.
- Learn one timeline pattern.

Week 3 - Harmony

Chords and cadences.

- Build primary triads in three keys.
- Identify five cadences by ear.
- Play I-IV-V-I in two keys.

Week 4 - Form

Structure.

- Map the form of one song.
- Mark section boundaries and why.
- Write a 15-mark answer.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any fundamentals of music theory workbook covering scales, intervals and triads.
- An introduction to African music covering polyrhythm and ensemble organisation.
- A sight-singing or ear-training resource for interval recognition.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What is the interval pattern of a major scale?

Answer: Tone, tone, semitone, tone, tone, tone, semitone.

2. How many semitones are in a perfect fifth?

Answer: Seven.

3. What is a triad?

Answer: A chord of three notes built in thirds from a root.

4. Define polyrhythm.

Answer: The simultaneous use of two or more contrasting rhythmic patterns that do not share a simple subdivision.

5. Why is the standard pattern important?

Answer: It functions as a timeline that anchors the ensemble and organises the cyclical structure of the music.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write out all major scales up to four sharps and flats.
- [ ] Practise reading treble and bass clefs daily for a week.
- [ ] Sing and identify ten intervals.
- [ ] Build major, minor and diminished triads on five roots.
- [ ] Clap a 3:2 polyrhythm steadily for a minute.
- [ ] Transcribe four bars of a recorded pattern.
- [ ] Test yourself with a short dictation.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: